

Episode 202: About *Revolutionary Girl Utena* – Part 4

Currently in the midst of an intense crunch for *Wake Up, Girls!*, and three members from the real Wake Up, Girls! came to the production site for coverage. Real idols! They were going around the studio having photos taken for some purpose. Eventually they visited my colour design room too, and were getting excited looking at the WUG colour samples displayed on the monitor!

Even so, Wake Up, Girls! are young! Generally all under 20! Teenagers! Since I don't have young women this young around me, when they talk to me with such sparkling feeling, this old man gets confused about how to respond! (laugh) But when I think about it, there are many fathers out there my age who have daughters about their age! How do they manage? Amazing. That alone deserves respect!

...When I told such a story to a certain S-san sitting next to me who assists with my colour design, she said "When I was around that age, I didn't talk to my father at all!" (sweat) Hmm, hang in there fathers!

Now then.

The vaguely decided broadcast start period became clear. The production site finally began moving significantly toward that broadcast start.

While *Revolutionary Girl Utena*'s main story parts were created by the production group "BE-PAPAS" led by Ikuhara, the actual work body for animation production itself would be handled by J.C.Staff. Specifically, story (scripts) and character settings - various animation-related settings were BE-PAPAS, and I think storyboard and direction staff arrangements including who would handle which episodes were also BE-PAPAS management? J.C.Staff was everything from rough animation onward - in-betweening, finishing (仕上), art, photography work management, schedule management including sound-related work.

So work sites were also separated - at BE-PAPAS studio in Nishi-Ogikubo were Director Ikuhara and main staff, individual episode directors, and some animators, while production management and actual work were at J.C.Staff in Mitaka Shimoren-jaku (at that time).

"Hello! I'm Matsukura!" One day Ikuhara introduced me to Matsukura, who was the head of that production team. Matsukura from J.C.Staff is now a skilled? powerful? producer of "this person exists!" level in the industry (laugh), but even from our first meeting his aura and dignity were impressive. Even though we hadn't worked together on anything yet, I remember feeling very reassured by him and his production team. And hiding behind that Matsukura was one petite woman. It was Tanahashi Mayumi, brought by Matsukura as *Utena's* colour design.

As I briefly wrote earlier, at that time I belonged to Toei Animation and work there was basically my main focus, so I couldn't get fully involved in *Utena's* main story. So we needed to properly establish a separate colour designer to handle main story work. My job pillars were designing colours for each character and creating basic colour change patterns for evening and night. Tanahashi would inherit things that got OK from my designs and further build up *Utena's* world - roughly that division and flow.

For character colour design, I'd been building up by colouring setting copies with Copic, but at that stage I had the actual cel paint colour specifications somewhat completed in my mind. So I'd specify actual paint colour numbers for that design and have test colouring done on actual cels. From there became Tanahashi's work? Actually I was planning to do the cel painting work myself, and had Matsukura prepare a full set of Taiyo Shikisai paints used by J.C.Staff at BE-PAPAS studio, but when it came time to start, I believe Toei Animation's theatrical work was at a critical stage (I think *The File of Young Kindaichi*), so I ended up asking Tanahashi.

So we lined up the completed cel colour samples to check balance. While colour tones themselves were decided with Copic, the settling when painted with cel paints was different, so we confirmed by lining up actual cel completions. This was quite

spectacular! Beyond imagination and expectation in my mind, quite substantial presence. While each character's assertiveness was solid, overall it was very well-balanced and properly finished as one "world." "Yes! We won!" It was considerable satisfaction in a self-praising way (laugh).

Next, while placing those completed normal colour samples on art boards, I did basic evening and night colour specifications. Yes. At this point I first placed them on art boards to create colour tones. When initially creating basic (normal) colours, I didn't use art boards at all. Characters first. For character-centered works, balance between characters is the game, so first taking balance with just characters and building - that's my basic style, and that hasn't essentially changed even now that we're digital. Then we develop background balance while maintaining that inter-character balance.

Of course, in this era at this time, anime cels and backgrounds drawn on paper were actually shot with lenses, so due to the material feeling of cels and backgrounds respectively, plus air existing between cel + background and lens, to put it roughly, most combinations resulted in matching screens. However, that's about normal screens. So-called "scene colour changes" like night and evening naturally need properly aligned direction.

Now, around when main character colour tones were generally complete, Episode 1 work had finally begun. As with any work, until Episode 1 is completed, while each staff member has completion images in their heads, no one has seen that work's finished form or completion. Creating works where no one knows the "correct answer" gradually takes solid shape through the process of making Episode 1.

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